

Your T-shirt's Secret Journey: From Farm to Fashion in India!

Ever wondered about the amazing journey your favourite T-shirt takes before it lands in your wardrobe?

More Than Just a Shirt!

Look around you – chances are, someone nearby is wearing a T-shirt! They're super popular, right? In India, T-shirts are a huge deal, making up a big part of our country's massive textile industry. India isn't just a big user of T-shirts; we're also a global leader in making and sending them all over the world! Places like Tiruppur in Tamil Nadu are famous worldwide for their amazing knitwear. But did you know India's textile story goes back over 5000 years, with cotton farming happening even in the Indus Valley Civilization?

Ubiquitous

Found everywhere, very common.

Knitwear

Clothes made by knitting yarn, like T-shirts.

DID YOU KNOW?

India's textile history dates back over 5000 years to the Indus Valley Civilization!

What's Your T-shirt Made Of?

Most T-shirts start with cotton, a soft, natural fibre. India is the world's largest producer of cotton! Farmers in states like Maharashtra, Gujarat, and Telangana grow this 'white gold'. Raw cotton, called 'kapas', can cost around Rs 6,000-8,000 for 100 kg. Sometimes, T-shirts are blended with polyester fibre, often from places like Surat in Gujarat. Polyester makes your T-shirt more durable and less wrinkly, which is pretty cool for active kids like you!

Kharif crop

Crops grown during the monsoon season (June-July).

Quintal

A unit of weight equal to 100 kilograms.

DID YOU KNOW?

India produces a massive 23% of all the cotton grown globally!

From Cotton Fields to Yarn Rolls

The journey begins on farms where cotton is picked, often by hand. Then, it goes to a 'ginning' mill. Imagine a big machine separating the fluffy cotton fibre (called lint) from its seeds. This lint is then pressed into huge bales, each weighing 170 kg! Next, these bales travel to spinning mills, often in Tamil Nadu or Punjab. Here, the cotton fibres are cleaned, straightened, and twisted together to create strong, thin 'yarn' – the threads that will become your T-shirt.

Ginning

The process of separating cotton fibres from their seeds.

Lint

The fluffy cotton fibre after seeds are removed.

Bales

Large, tightly packed bundles of cotton lint.

Spinning

The process of twisting fibres into yarn.

DID YOU KNOW?

A single bale of cotton lint weighs 170 kg!

Knitting, Colouring, and Stitching!

Now for the magic! The yarn reaches places like Tiruppur, where 'circular knitting machines' weave it into a continuous tube of fabric, often 'single jersey' knit. One machine can make 200-400 kg of fabric daily! Next, the fabric gets a colourful makeover in dyeing units. It's cleaned, bleached, dyed to your favourite colours, and then 'finished' to make it soft and prevent shrinkage. Finally, in garment factories in Tiruppur or Bengaluru, skilled workers cut the fabric using patterns and stitch it into T-shirts, adding prints or embroidery.

Knitting

Creating fabric by interlocking loops of yarn.

Single jersey

A common, stretchy knit structure for T-shirts.

Dyeing

Adding colour to fabric.

Finishing

Processes to improve fabric feel, stability, and reduce shrinkage.

ETPs (Effluent Treatment Plants)

Facilities that clean wastewater before it's released.

DID YOU KNOW?

A single circular knitting machine can produce 200-400 kg of fabric every day!

Your T-shirt's Grand Entrance!

Once stitched, your T-shirt isn't quite ready for you yet! It travels from the factory to big warehouses and distributors in cities like Mumbai, Delhi, or Bengaluru. This is 'logistics' – making sure products get where they need to go efficiently. From there, it reaches your favourite stores like Zudio, Max Fashion, or Reliance Trends, or even online stores like Myntra. You can find a basic T-shirt for just Rs 199 at Zudio, or a super stylish one like BLUORNG's for Rs 5,900!

Logistics

The detailed planning and management of moving goods.

E-commerce

Buying and selling goods and services over the internet.

DID YOU KNOW?

T-shirts in India can range from Rs 199 (Zudio) to Rs 5,900 (BLUORNG)!

The Price, Our Planet, and You

Ever wondered why some T-shirts cost more? The price covers raw materials, knitting, dyeing, stitching, transport, and the store's profit. The retailer's margin can be a big chunk! You also pay GST, either 5% or 18% depending on the T-shirt's price. But there's more: making T-shirts uses a lot of water and energy, and can cause pollution. That's why certifications like GOTS and Better Cotton Initiative (BCI) are important, ensuring your T-shirt is made in a more eco-friendly way.

GST (Goods and Services Tax)

A tax on most goods and services.

Carbon footprint

The total amount of greenhouse gases caused by an activity.

Effluent

Liquid waste discharged from factories.

GOTS (Global Organic Textile Standard)

A certification for organic fibres.

BCI (Better Cotton Initiative)

A program promoting sustainable cotton farming.

DID YOU KNOW?

The retailer's profit and overheads can make up 35% of your T-shirt's price!

India's Textile Powerhouse

Our government knows how important the textile industry is! The Ministry of Textiles has schemes like the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) Scheme, which gives money to companies that make high-quality garments and fabrics. The SAMARTH scheme helps train workers, while PM MITRA Parks are creating special zones for textile factories to make things easier and cheaper. India exports T-shirts and yarn to countries like Bangladesh, USA, and the UK, showing our strength in the global market!

PLI Scheme (Production Linked Incentive Scheme)

Government incentives to boost domestic manufacturing.

PM MITRA Parks

Mega textile parks with world-class facilities to support the industry.

Skill development

Training people to improve their abilities for jobs.

DID YOU KNOW?

The PLI Scheme for textiles has a huge budget of Rs 10,683 crore to boost manufacturing!

Discussion questions

- ? Considering the long journey and many steps involved, what do you think is the most challenging part of making a T-shirt?
- ? If you had to choose between a cheaper T-shirt made without eco-friendly practices and a slightly more expensive one with certifications like GOTS, which would you pick and why?
- ? How do you think schemes like PM MITRA Parks help local communities and the environment in India?

Key takeaways

- Your T-shirt travels through many hands and machines, from farm to fashion.
- India is a global leader in cotton production and T-shirt manufacturing.
- Making a T-shirt involves farming, ginning, spinning, knitting, dyeing, and stitching.
- T-shirt prices vary greatly, reflecting brand, material, and retail costs.
- Sustainable practices are becoming crucial to reduce the environmental impact of T-shirt production.
- The Indian government actively supports the textile industry through various schemes.

Further Reading

Amended Technology Upgradation Fund Scheme (ATUFS)

Schemes and Services - Ministry of Textiles

Textile-Related Schemes in India

Schemes launched by the Government in Textile sector for employment generation - PIB

Textile-Related Schemes in India – Citi India - The Confederation of Indian Textile Industry

Chapter 61 - GST Rates and HSN Codes for T-Shirts and Singlets - Aditya Birla Capital

History of Indian Textile Industry

Amended Technology Upgradation Fund Scheme (ATUFS): In Detail - Testbook

Cotton Producing States In India - SATHEE CUET